

“I think this the **strongest position** by nature upon which to **fight a battle** that I ever saw.”

LIEUTENANT GENERAL WINFIELD S. HANCOCK, UNION ARMY, JULY 1, 1863

Fighting withdrawal

Through the rest of the afternoon and into early evening, Longstreet's troops attacked Sickles' corps. At the Peach Orchard, Devil's Den, and Wheatfield, Sickles' men, reinforced by brigades from the Fifth and Sixth Corps, retreated and counterattacked until finally forced to yield their positions. The climax on the southern end of the field occurred at Little Round Top, as Hood's tired and thirsty Alabamans and Texans assaulted—and almost captured—the anchor to Meade's position. Colonel Joshua L. Chamberlain and his 20th Maine would become famous for their defense of the hill's southern slope. Moreover, it is likely that Meade would have sent in the bulk of Sixth Corps to retake it. Union numbers and interior lines were starting to make a difference.

Robert E. Lee was discouraged by the events of July 2. When cavalry under General Jeb Stuart rejoined the Confederate army that evening, Stuart got only the tersest of greetings. He boasted he had brought 100 captured Union wagons. “What good are they to me now?” Lee replied.

A fatal mistake

Lee's decision to attack the Union center on the third day of Gettysburg has been long debated. His judgment may have been impaired—he was tired and suffering from diarrhea and a heart condition. He thought he had thinned Meade's line by obliging him to reinforce his flanks the previous day. He also believed his men could do anything he asked of them and was determined to win the